

Certified Tough

When Panasonic says their notebooks are tough, they mean it

Mithun Mohandas | mithun@digit.in

Panasonic refreshed their CF-SV8 lineup of ruggedised notebooks in India and we got to speak with the folks over at Panasonic to understand more about the enterprise notebook market in India.

Q Could you elaborate more on the segmentation that you have within the enterprise business in India?

Panasonic: Within Panasonic, the division that manages the enterprise business is called System Solution Division (SSD) and I run that entire business. And within SSD, we've got three large businesses, one of which is the Toughbook business which is headed by Gunjan and this business includes ruggedised laptops and handhelds. Then there's another business called Panasonic Solutions Network, under which we have products such as video door phones, security cameras, EPABX, telephones and similar products. Lastly, the third business is the Display Solutions Group which has panels and projectors which are used in corporate offices, malls and the projectors are built for cinema halls.

Now if you look at Panasonic as an organisation, we've primarily been a hardware company. It was three-years ago that we decided that the way the entire business is evolving, future customers would not be looking at products but solutions which the companies could be offering. With that intent, we created a business unit called India Innovations Centre (IIC) under which we started creating solutions using the products that

we have. With our ruggedised solutions portfolio, we started collaborating with a lot of ecosystem partners with whom we now give specialised solutions to our enterprise customers which are targeted specifically at their needs.

We don't look at our business from certain point products, it's more around the kind of solutions that we're selling in each business.

Q What new products are you launching in the rugged series?

Panasonic: We've been in the business for more than 10 years in India and we've been the market leaders with close to 60 per cent market share. The new product line we're bringing in, the CF-SV8 ruggedised business laptops, are a revised and enhanced version of what we had earlier.

Q Are these new refreshes targeted towards a particular niche? Where is the demand for ruggedised laptops?

Panasonic: If you look at the ruggedised laptops or handhelds, then the use cases are very specific. The kind of ruggedness that goes into these laptops may not be required by all enterprise users. Secondly, the kind of computing that these products can do may not be required by all users. And thirdly, this product can withstand a fall of around 2.5 feet and the vibration test that it undergoes is close to around 100 kgs of force, the battery life of this particular product varies from 10.5 to 15.5 hours

depending on the kind of battery that you put in. All these features and the choice of I/O options you have available is not required by regular users. These products would ideally be going into places which

have a requirement for ruggedised builds. The CF-SV8 also comes with a Japanese keyboard so it's also suited for companies which serve Japanese clientele.



Mr. Vijay Wadhawan, Group Chief, System Solution Business

Q Do these laptops undergo Mil Spec certification?

Panasonic: If you consider the CF-SV8, it's not Mil Spec but the other rugged devices that we have in our portfolio which are the rugged laptops and rugged tablets are Mil certified. We have MIL-STD-810G certification for vibration and shocks and we have IP65 for dust and water

resistance. And in some rugged tablets, we have IP68 certification as well since they are designed for extreme conditions. However, the CF-SV8 is what we call Business Rugged. We have three rugged lineups – Business Rugged, Semi-Rugged and Fully-Rugged. Semi-Rugged and Fully-Rugged have these types of certifications. Business Rugged laptops don't have such certifications but we do certify that they can handle 2.5-feet drops and 100 kg force vibrations, aside from the long battery-life.

Q Do you have any major Govt. contracts for these rugged devices?

Panasonic: We have divided the market into several verticals. The Police vertical is a rather big vertical and we have deployed our devices in 7-8 states in India. UP Police being the largest one, we have almost 4000 devices deployed, similarly we have deployed units with the Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh, Bangalore, etc Police forces. We've also deployed with the Bangladesh police and we have several Defense related deployments. Manufacturing and automotive sectors also use our devices. These are the primary sectors where we've been selling our devices in India and we have about 500 big customers in India who are using our devices. **Q**



Mr. Gunjan Sachdev, Business Head Toughbooks at Panasonic India